Logical Reasoning Guide to Question and Reasoning Types

Question Types 2
- Agree/Disagree 2
- Flaw 3
- Main Conclusion 6
- Method 8
- Most Supported 10
- Must be True 12
- Must be False 14
- Necessary Assumption 17
- Paradox 20
- Parallel 22
- Parallel Flaw 24
- Principle-Strengthen 26
- Principle-Conform 27
- Role 28
- Strengthen 30
- Weaken 31

Reasoning Types 33
- Causation 33
- Conditional Logic 35
- Comparison 36
- Explain Curious Fact 39
- Famous Flaws 41

Question Types

Agree/Disagree

Keywords

Disagree, agree, point at issue

Examples

The dialogue above most supports that Pam and Dawn disagree about which of the following?
Based on their statements, Jerome and AJ are committed to agreeing to which of the following?
Which of the following is the point at issue between Martinez and Howie?

Stimulus Tendencies

The first person's statements more often resemble an argument, while the second person's often don't have any explicit conclusion. Ultimately, though, we don't care which claim is a background vs. premise vs. conclusion. We're just hunting for the claims that clash / match.
Most of the time, the claim they agree/disagree with is explicit. Only on harder ones will we have to ask ourselves about whether their point of (dis)agreement is an assumption.

Pre-phrase Goal

We want to try to dial this in pretty specifically. Since we are usually locating one and only one claim in Person 1's statements that Person 2 (dis)agrees with, we can be very proactive about looking for answer choices that sound like that claim.

Reading Goal

1. Read each person's statements (Don't worry about finding their "conclusion" or "support")
2. After you've read each person's paragraph, go back and revisit each claim the 1st person made.
3. For each claim, ask yourself if the 2nd person agreed / disagreed / we don't know.
4. If there aren't any explicit claims that the 2nd person is agreeing / disagreeing with, then ask yourself whether the 1st person is assuming anything the 2nd person would agree/disagree with.

Correct Answers

On a Disagree or Point at Issue task, the correct answer is a claim for which we can

infer that one of the people would agree and the other person would disagree (they would agree to its logical contradiction).

On an Agree question, the correct answer is a claim for which we can infer that each person would agree.

Frequently, the correct answer uses the phrasing of one person, to express the opinion of the other person. For example, if the first person says, "Rigatoni is the most traditional form of pasta" and the second person disagreed by saying, "Hogwash. Spaghetti predates rigatoni by two centuries", then the answer would either...

Use person 1's language to express person 2's opinion:
*"Rigatoni is **not** the most traditional form of pasta"*

Or use person 2's language to express person 1's opinion:
"Spaghetti does not predate rigatoni by two centuries"

Incorrect Answers

- **Both Agree** - On disagree questions, there are often answers that both people agreed to or would presumably agree to
- **Both Disagree** - On agree questions, there is often one answer that shows where the two people disagreed
- **Out of Scope** - The most common trap answer brings up a topic that one (or both) of the people never addressed.
- **Too Strong** - This can be tricky to see because the Too Strong version of a lot of trap answers is the contradiction. Remember, for a correct answer, we can infer that one person would agree, and we can infer that the other person would agree to the logical contradiction (the negation).

So if we see an answer like:

- (A) Some attempts by the government to intervene are more problematic than the problem they attempted to solve.

It's easy to believe that one person would agree to that weakly worded claim. But would the other person disagree, i.e. would they agree that "Attempts by the govt to intervene **never** make the situation more problematic than before"? Probably not.

Flaw

Keywords

Vulnerable to criticism, flaw, questionable reasoning, errors of reasoning

Examples

The argument is most vulnerable to criticism because it ...
Fred commits which of the following errors of reasoning?

The publicist's reasoning is flawed because she ...

Stimulus tendencies

These are arguments that either have a noteworthy Assumption, are vulnerable to a certain sort of Objection, or make some sort of Dubious / Illicit Move.

There are about a baker's dozen **Famous Flaws** that show up a lot on these problems, especially within the answer choices:

- **Necessary vs. Sufficient** - Taking a conditional relationship and but then illegally thinking through it in backwards or opposite fashion.
- **Causal** - Overconfidently concluding one possible causal interpretation of a curious fact, usually a Correlation, when other possible interpretations exist
- **Part vs. Whole** - Assuming that a trait that is true of each Part of a collective is therefore true of the Whole, or vice versa.
- **Unproven vs. Proven False** - Pointing out that someone failed to prove X is true and then concluding that this means that X is false.
- **Ad Hominem** - Dismissing a point of view because the source has a biased interest or has conflicting past behavior.
- **Sampling** - Extrapolating/generalizing too readily from a small sample, while failing to consider that the sample might be biased, too small, or unrepresentative.
- **Irrelevant Rebuttal** - Rebutting someone's claim or argument by mischaracterizing it in some Straw Man way or by bringing up something wholly irrelevant to the original claim.
- **False Choice** - Acting as though you have to choose between two options, as though they're a binary / exhaustive set, even though you never established those are the only options.
- **Relative vs. Absolute** - Getting mixed up with Percents vs. Amounts, or confusing more/less language with yes/no language.
- **Inappropriate Appeal** - Your evidence is a plea for sympathy, you cite an "authority" without establishing credibility, or you favor one source's opinion over another source's, without justifying your pick.

Almost always wrong answers:

- **Circular Reasoning** - The premise of an argument restates or assumes the conclusion.
- **Internal Contradiction** - Something the author says undermines or contradicts something else they say
- **Equivocation** - Using the same "term" or concept to mean two very different things.

Reading Goal

At its simplest, Flaw just wants us to read some confused blowhard's crappy argument and say, "Objection, Dr. Stupid did this." Thus, try to read the argument and respond with an objection *to the reasoning*. Is there a distinction the author isn't perceiving? Is something too strong? Is something irrelevant? Does the author's thinking feel like it's cheating in some way?

Since the answers will be doing so, we should feel free to speak any of three languages. "The argument is flawed because ...

- ... the author assumes X" (**Assumption** answers)
- ... isn't it possible that Y is true?" (**Objection** answers)
- ... the author made this illegal move" (**Description** answers)

One framework that usually works is, "Just because your Premise is true, doesn't mean your Conclusion is true". You might not realize you're reading a Part to Whole flaw, but you can help your brain by saying, "Just because *each member of the team is efficient* doesn't mean that *the team will be efficient*".

Correct Answer

You can always ask two questions of the correct answer:

- Is this **descriptively accurate**? (If not, eliminate)
- Is this a **logical problem** with going from Premise to Conclusion? (if not, eliminate)

Depending on the phrasing of the answer choice, you can also pose one of these three questions to yourself:

• *Was* the author **Assuming** that, or is this Too Strong / Out of Scope? • *Would* this be an **Objection**, or is it Too Weak / Irrelevant to the Conclusion? • *Does* this abstract wording **Match** the Premise and the Conclusion/Assumption?

ASSUMPTION phrasings
takes for granted / presumes / assumes / fails to establish ... that
X **OBJECTION phrasings**
fails to consider / ignores / neglects / overlooks the possibility ... that
Y **MATCH phrasings**
concludes C on the basis of P / infers, on the grounds that P, that C / confuses P with C
takes for granted that C because P / fails to consider that even if P, may not be C

Incorrect Answers

- **Too Strong** - The assumption answers are very often too strong. So many wrong answers accuse the author of *taking for granted* some strongly worded claim. A lot of them also say the author concluded X *merely* on the basis of Y. That means that Y was the only shred of evidence, and that's frequently not the case.
- **Bad Match** - So many answers are descriptively inaccurate. Either the premise language in the answer doesn't resemble the actual evidence, the conclusion language in the answer doesn't resemble the actual conclusion, or both. As soon as you find a mismatching part, you should bail from that answer.
- **Reversed / Opposite wording** - Lots of answers have the right ideas in the wrong order
- **Wrong Flaw** - Almost 50% of the answers in Flaw go back to the top ten Famous

Flaws, so we're routinely seeing old friends like *Sampling* and thinking, "This wasn't one of *those*."
- **Contradicted** - It says the author "failed to consider" something she definitely considered.

Main Conclusion

Keywords

Main conclusion, main point

Examples

Which of the following best expresses the main conclusion of the argument? Which of the following is Eddie's main point?

Stimulus Tendencies

LSAC is seeking to make it harder than usual to find the Conclusion. So it's very rare to see the Conclusion be the final claim, prefaced by anything obvious like Therefore / Thus / So, though sometimes it will be that.

Rather than making the conclusion the last claim, in more than 90% of Main Conclusion questions, **the conclusion appears, then evidence comes after**.
These are the two most common places they stash the conclusion:

- **First sentence**
- After a **But / Yet / However** pivot.

Other times, the Conclusion will be indirectly revealed by **Support language** like "for, after all, to see this". They usually wouldn't use an obvious Premise indicator like "since" or "because".
Sometimes, our best clue about where the conclusion is will be an **Opinion Indicator** like "probably, apparently, evidently".

Beware that there may be **Intermediate Conclusions.** They will pass the Support test because they will have their own premise. But they are there to support the Main Conclusion.
Beware that there may be **Causal-Indicator** words that look like Conclusion-Indicator words. You can use "thus, therefore, hence, so"

Pre-phrase Goal

This is the most lovable question type ever. We just have to find the conclusion and reiterate to ourselves, "Okay, don't overcomplicate this --- just go find that claim we identified as the conclusion".
Many conclusions will be some form of rebuttals or other claim that uses referential language (pronouns, like "this, that, they, such")

If so, we want to take the time to replace the pronoun with its reference language.
F.e. Some people propose laws that would require mandatory background checks before owning a gun. However, such laws won't affect the homicide rate. Almost all homicides are committed by people who would pass the background check proposed in this law.
If we correct identified the 2nd sentence as the conclusion, our job is to remind ourselves what "**such** laws" refers to and use that language in its place when we're saying the conclusion back to ourselves.
"Okay, the conclusion is that [*laws requiring mandatory background checks] won't affect the homicide rate*."

Reading Goal

1. Find the conclusion.
2. Make sure that it
3. Sounds like **Author's Opinion** (facts ≠ conclusions)
4. Is **Supported** by at least one explicit claim.

Correct Answer

The correct answer just reproduces the meaning of the Conclusion. Sometimes it's a verbatim regurgitation. More commonly, they use synonyms or inverted syntax to present an equivalent meaning that still looks a little different.

F.e. If the conclusion appeared in the argument as "not all tornadoes should be avoided", then an equivalent claim would be "some tornadoes should not be avoided".
If you didn't already do the **2-part Conclusion Check** when you were first reading the argument and determining which claim is the conclusion, you can do it now (or again)
--

- Is this answer expressing an **Opinion** from our Author? (facts ≠ conclusions) • Was this answer **Supported** by at least one explicit claim?

Incorrect Answers

- **Premise**
- **Last Claim Trap** - They know that we wish for the last claim to be the Conclusion • **Intermediate Conclusion**
- **What Next** - These present a claim that was never said, but they don't like the **next** thing the author would probably say
- **Necessary Assumption** - These feel tempting because we can tell that they are a correct inference about the author's thinking, but the Conclusion is an explicit claim, whereas these assumptions are implicit; they were never said

Method

Keywords

Proceeds by, responds by, argumentative technique, method of reasoning

Examples

The diplomat's argument proceeds by ...
Charlie responds to Sarah in which of the following ways?
Which of the following is a technique

Stimulus Tendencies

There's a pretty consistent list of argument moves that they test us on:

- Analogy
- Rules Out Competing Options
- Implications of Logic
- Make a Distinction
- Alternate Explanation for a phenomenon
- (Counter)example to a General Principle
- Point Out Dubious Assumption
- Raise an Overlooked Consideration

You don't have to memorize this list, but if you become more familiar with it, you may find it easier to anticipate possible answer wording. Here's a quick example of each of these:

- **Analogy** - Parents want to force their children to practice the piano. But *just as* you can't force the blossom of a rose before it's ready, we should give children the time they need to come to the piano on their own terms.
- **Rules Out Competing Options** - Eliza wants her child Herbert to learn an instrument. Herbert is only interested in drums, piano, and flute. Since drums and piano are too big to fit inside Eliza's apartment, she should buy Herbert a flute.
- **Implications of Logic** - Some claim that we should always be honest with people. But if this were true, then when my daughter plays me the new song she just "wrote" on piano and asks me if I like it, I would be needlessly discouraging her if I honestly told her that I thought it was hot garbage.
- **Make a Distinction** - Many parents who live in apartment building are worried about their children practicing a musical instrument at home and annoying the nearby tenants. However, it is primarily low frequency sounds that penetrate walls, due to their longer waveforms. Thus, a flute, which is primarily a high-frequency instrument, is fine to practice in an apartment building, as its sound is unlikely to disturb neighbors.
- **Alternate Explanation for a phenomenon** - The rise in music recordings that use sampled drums, rather than live drums, has been attributed to the ascendancy

of hip-hop as one of the most popular styles of music. However, it is also possible that more music makers are turning to sampled drums because sound-editing programs like Garage Band, which makes adding sampled drums to a recording very easy, have become standard software in many computers.

- **(Counter)example to a General Principle** - It's often said that you never get a second chance to make a first impression. The first night Sheila met her eventual husband, she said a lot of embarrassing things. However, he was so blackout drunk at the time, that when he saw her at a mutual friend's party a month later, he didn't realize he had ever met her before.
- **Point Out Dubious Assumption** - MARK: When I visited my niece a year ago, she was really into those *Twilight* books, so for Christmas I'm getting her a *Twilight* calendar. LEROY: Children's entertainment obsessions change on an almost-quarterly basis. Are you sure she's still into *Twilight*?
- **Raise an Overlooked Consideration** - ABDUL: Sharon ended up getting a 152 on her LSAT, which is only a 50th percentile score, so I guess that tutor she hired was a waste of money. SARAFINA: She had been stuck at 140 for months until she started working with the tutor, and now she has a score that could get her into law school.

Reading Goal

If we're reading one person's argument:

=1. Find the conclusion.
2. Find the support.
3. Try to characterize the evidence (analogy, counterexample, citing an authority, etc.) or the way that the author arrived at her conclusion (ruling out other options, looking at the implications of a statement the opponent/the author makes, etc.)

If we're reading two people's statements and describing the response:

1. Read both paragraphs
2. Ask yourself whether the 2nd person was adding onto the 1st person's argument or pushing back against something.
3. If they were pushing back (much more common), were they arguing against the evidence (basically never happens), arguing against an assumption, accepting the evidence and arguing for a difference conclusion, or just creating some doubt by raising alternative possibilities or overlooked considerations?
4. Did the second person actually conclude anything, or just provide food for thought?

Pre-phrase Goal

If you can match up the argument you've read with anything from the list of common answers (analogy, example, distinction, alternative explanation, etc.) then cue up that language. About 1/3 of these deal with analogies. Otherwise, be okay letting the answer choices guide you. It's often very hard to predict the wording of the eventual answer choice.

Correct Answer

The correct answer doesn't say anything descriptively wrong. The other four do. Much of what we have to do when analyzing these answer choices is match up one abstract phrase with the evidence and another with the conclusion. Pay attention to wording indicating which part of an answer deals with Conclusion, which deals with Evidence, and which deals with an Opposing position.

- Concludes **C** on the basis of **E**
- Infers, from the claim that **E**, that **C**
- Attempts to **C** by **E**
- Demonstrates **C** by **E**
- Claiming **C** because of **E**
- Basing a conclusion on the claim that **E**
- Refuting **O** on the grounds that **E**

Answers choices describing a 2nd person's response often just make one claim:

- Disputes X
- Criticizes X
- Provides X
- Agrees with X but argues Y

Incorrect Answer

There aren't really patterns or types of correct answers, because they're all wrong for being descriptively inaccurate about something. The one frequently recurring wrong answer on Describe the Response type tasks, though, is that the 2nd person responded by "**denying the validity of the evidence**". We know that's not LSAT's style. The 2nd person never does that.

Most Supported

Keywords

Statements, information, passage, most support which answer, which answer is most supported, most illustrates

Examples

If the statements are true, they most strongly support which of the following? The information given most supports which one of the following? Which of the following propositions is best illustrated by the situation described?

Stimulus Tendencies

These are almost always FACTS, not ARGUMENTS (when they are an argument, the tested inference is usually very similar to a necessary assumption). The stimulus frequently features some blend of Conditional Logic, Causality, Comparisons, Pivots, or Quantified language

Conditional Logic - We might have to chain together multiple conditionals, and/or we might be able to apply a conditional rule to a provided fact (the fact usually triggers the contrapositive).

Causality - There are some chains of causality that let us infer that First thing causes Last thing (A causes B, which leads to C **let us infer that** A leads to C). There are also some examples of *Solve the Causal Mystery*, in which the most supportable answer is a speculative guess about what could account for the facts. Most commonly, there is a *Causal Difference-Maker* identified or suggested. Explicit causal language looks like *because of this / due to this / this allows / this makes possible / this leads to*. Implicit causality is more like "Thing A and B are similar when it comes to X, but different when it comes to Y. So, if they are different when it comes to Z, then Y was probably the causal difference-maker that accounts for Z".

Comparisons / Contrasts - Many *Fill in the Blank* questions (Logical Completion) have a *complete the analogy* feel. They tell us that "Thing A is like Thing B. And since X would be true of Thing A, _____ ", setting us up for answer that reinforces "X would be true of Thing B".
A lot of comparison/contrast ideas are setups for correct answers that reinforce *the Causal Difference-Maker*. When the paragraph *Ends with a Pivot*, i.e. the last idea is introduced with a *but / yet / however* pivot, the correct answer usually safely reconciles the last idea with what came before it.

Quantified / Mathematical - These are much more common on Must Be True questions, but if we see wording like "some, most, all, few", then the correct answer might be recognizing that two qualities overlap at least once, or that one group must be bigger than another.

Reading Goal

1. As we read facts, we're looking for two or more ideas that we could synthesize. Look for clues about where that synthesis might come, by keeping your eyes peeled for Conditional, Causal, Math-y, or Comparison / Contrast language. In particular, look out for *overlapping* ideas. An idea that shows up more than once is often the conduit to chaining something together, triggering a rule, or otherwise making an inference.
2. If you see a Pivot, think about what it would sound like to safely combines what comes after the pivot with what came before.
3. If it's Logical Completion (fill in the blank), think about a safely worded conclusion that would pull together the thoughts already mentioned.

Correct Answer

The most provable claim there is always the correct answer. Sometimes it'll feel 99% must be true. Other times it will feel more speculative, but it's always the most supported. It does *not* need to use all the facts; in fact, it's a very common template that the inference involves combining the first and last claims (while the middle claim acts as filler).

Correct answers will often have easy-to-prove language like "some, could, can, may, might, sometimes, not always, not all, need not".

It's very rare for the correct answer to be derived from only one idea, so you should normally feel like in order to support the correct answer, you need to combine 2 or more facts.

Incorrect Answers

- **Too Strong** - Words like "*all, none, only, unless"*, as well as medium-strong words like "*typically, usually, most, generally, tends to, primarily"* often are stronger than what the information has told us.
- **Out of Scope** - Answers that bring up things for which we were provided no information are almost always wrong
- **Illegal Reversals / Negations** - If there is any conditional logic involved, there will usually be at least one trap answer that represents the conditional logic in backwards or opposite fashion.
- **Unknown Comparisons** - A lot of correct answers take an absolute adjective like "successful" and try to make a comparative claim like "more successful" out of it.
- **Contradicted** - Some answers actually go *against* what we read.

Must be True

Keywords

Statements, information, passage, must be true, properly inferred, follows

logically **Examples**

If the statements are true, which one of the following must be true?
Which of the following can be inferred by the information in the passage?

Stimulus Tendencies

These are FACTS, not ARGUMENTS.
The stimulus usually features some blend of Conditional / Quantified ideas.

Conditional Inferences

We often have to chain together multiple conditionals.
When we have a chain of ideas, such as A → B → C → D, the most likely correct answer would be A → D or the contrapositive ~D → ~A. But any subset of that chain can be properly inferred, such as A → C or B → D.
The other common setup is that we have a fact that triggers a conditional rule (usually by contrapositive) and lets us infer the outcome of the rule.
We may have 2 or 3 possible options identified, but through the course of ruling out all but 1 option, we are forced to infer that final option.

Quantified / Mathematical Inferences

If we see words like "some, most, all, few", then the correct answer might be testing that two qualities overlap at least once, or that one group must be bigger than another.

Most A's are B	Most A's are B
Most A's are C	Most B's are ~A
Some B are C	**More B's than A's**

All A's are B	Most A's are B
Some A's are C	All B's are C
Some B are C	**Most A's are C**

There are other mathematical ideas tested, relating to % change, averages, and inequalities.

- If x > y, and y > z, **then** x > z.
- If the avg score for Group A was 160, and the avg score for the non-teachers in the group was 152, **then** the avg score for the teachers in the group had to be higher than 160.
- If my rent is higher now than five years ago, but my rent represents that same proportion of my salary as it did five years ago, **then** my salary now is higher than five years ago.

Reading Goal

As we read facts, we're looking for two or more ideas that we could synthesize. Look for clues about where that synthesis might come, by keeping your eyes peeled for Conditional, Quantified, or otherwise Mathematical ideas.

If you see Conditional language, look for a fact that triggers the rule (or, more likely, that triggers the contrapositive). If you have more than one Conditional, see if they chain together.

If you see a Pivot holding two mathematical ideas in tension, think about how to mathematically reconcile those two ideas.

If you see words like "Some / Most / All", ask yourself if you have two MOST facts about

the *same group*. If so, you can infer some overlap to the two qualities mentioned.

Correct Answer

It is provable based on only the provided information. It does *not* need to use all the facts; in fact, it's a very common template that the inference involves combining the first and last claims (while the middle claim acts as filler). It's very rare for the correct answer to be derived from only one idea, so you should normally feel like in order to support the correct answer, you need to combine 2 or more facts.

We would gravitate more towards answers with easy-to-prove language like "some, could, can, may, might, sometimes, not always, not all, need not". However, on Must Be True it is very common for the correct answer to have strong, black-and-white language. Since almost all the inferences come from Conditional or Mathematical thinking, they have the certainty that justifies strong language.

Incorrect Answers

- **Too Strong** - Words like *all, none, only, unless*, as well as medium-strong words like *typically, usually, most, generally, tends to, primarily* often are stronger than what the information has told us.
- **Out of Scope** - Answers that bring up things for which we were provided no information are almost always wrong
- **Reversed / Opposite logic** - If there is any conditional logic involved, there will usually be at least one trap answer that represents the conditional logic in backwards or opposite fashion.
- **Unknown Comparisons** - A lot of trap answers take an absolute adjective like "successful" and try to make a comparative claim like "more successful" out of it.
- **Contradicted** - Some answers actually go *against* what we read.

Must be False

Keywords

Must be false, incompatible, violates, most justifiably rejected

Examples

If the statements are true, which one of the following must be false? Based on the statements, each of the following could be true EXCEPT: Which of the following is LEAST COMPATIBLE with the information in the passage? Which of the following situations would violate the principle stated? The passage provides the strongest reason for rejecting which of the following?

Stimulus Tendencies

These are FACTS, not ARGUMENTS.
Must Be False question stems will usually have fact sets that include Conditional or Mathematical ideas.

Most Strongly Opposed question stems will usually have fact sets that feature a Similarity, Distinction, or Causal Difference-Maker.

Conditional

If we have **more than one** conditional, **chain them** together.
If we get a conditional and some fact about X applies to the trigger or to the contrapositive's trigger, then **infer the outcome** about X.
The correct answer will either contradict a conditional or conditional chain, by providing a case in which the trigger is true but the outcome isn't, or it will contradict an inference we derived from applying a conditional rule to fact X.

Mathematical

If we see words like "some, most, all, few", then the correct answer might be testing that two qualities overlap at least once, or that one group must be bigger than another.

Most A's are B	Most A's are B
Most A's are C	Most B's are ~A
Some B are C	**More B's than A's**

All A's are B	Most A's are B
Some A's are C	All B's are C
Some B are C	**Most A's are C**

There are other mathematical ideas tested, relating to % change, averages, and inequalities.

- If x > y, and y > z, **then** x > z.
- If the avg score for Group A was 160, and the avg score for the non-teachers in the group was 152, **then** the avg score for the teachers in the group had to be higher than 160.
- If my rent is higher now than five years ago, but my rent represents that same proportion of my salary as it did five years ago, **then** my salary now is higher than five years ago.

A correct answer would simply contradict whatever mathematical inference we're able to make.

Causal Difference-Maker

When Inference passages give us *causal language*, it factually establishes a causal influence. Look out for claims that get connected with language like

- Because of this
- Due to this
- This allows
- This makes possible
- By doing this
- This leads to

- Resulting in
- Contributes to".

Example: Patrick started chewing gum during his timed sections. ***By doing this,*** *his score improved*.
From that setup, it would be Must Be False-ish to say stuff like, "New routines never lead to improvement" or "The activities of your jaw are wholly independent of your performance on a test."

Reading Goal

Read this as though you're trying to make a *valid* inference, because they will often contradict a valid inference that can be made. Pay particular attention to whether there is any Conditional language. Can conditionals be chained together or can a rule be applied to a fact to derive a 2nd fact? If there's not any conditional logic, then there's likely a mathematical inference that can be made or a causal difference-maker situation discussed.

Correct Answer

It is CONTRADICTED by the information in the passage (or in *Least Compatible / Most Justifiably Rejected*, it is badly undermined by something in the passage).

If it's contradicting a conditional rule, it will establish that the trigger of the rule is happening, but the outcome is not happening. If it's contradicting an inference we made, it'll just sound like a negation of that inference or an impossibility, given the truth of that inference.

The correct answer is often **strongly worded**, because contradicting a strong statement requires something very weak. (if you say "all ice cream is delicious", I can contradict you with just one batch of Cousin Larry's Meatballs & Marshmallows ice cream).

Incorrect Answers

- **Weak Language** - It's hard to contradict a weak claim, because you'd have to prove something really strong. If someone said, "Some cops abuse their power", it would be hard to contradict them, since "some" is so weak and so contradicting it would require arguing that "no cops ever have abused their power".
- **Out of Scope** - Answers that bring up things for which we were provided no information are almost always wrong. We can't contradict an idea if we never covered that idea.
- **Reversed / Opposite logic** - There are illegal inferences, but that's not the same thing as a contradiction. Students frequently confuse Must Be False with "this can't be inferred". Don't conflate Must Be False with Unsupported. We're saying there IS support, for the OPPOSITE of this answer.

Necessary Assumption

Keywords

Assumption, depends, relies, requires, must be assumed, assumes, presupposes, takes for granted

Examples

Which of the following is an assumption on which the argument depends?
The author assumes which of the following?
The argument relies on which of the following assumptions?

Stimulus Tendencies

Necessary Assumption is a real mixed bag. Probably 60% of them are testing us on Idea Math, seeing if we notice a missing piece in the author's logic, similar to what we're doing on Sufficient Assumption and Principle-Justify questions. The other 40% are really testing us on Possible Objections, seeing if we can think of a way to accept the author's evidence but reject her conclusion, similar to what we're doing on Flaw, Strengthen, and Weaken.

When we see **Conditional** logic, other chains of ideas, or repeated ideas, (i.e. *going to a museum calms your soul, and a calm soul finds it easier to think*. *thus, going to a museum makes you more likely solve a difficult problem*), that's usually a strong sign that the correct answer will simply connect ideas that were only mentioned once (*you're more likely to solve a difficult problem if it's easier to think*).

When we see arguments that are using **Comparison** or **Causal** reasoning structures, then it's more likely that the correct answer is testing our ability to see where potential objections could arise. When an argument is comparative in nature, the author often needs to assume two things are relevantly similar or needs to assume there's a meaningful difference between the option they're choosing and the one they're rejecting. When an argument is causal in nature (i.e. the author's conclusion involves one possible causal explanation for some curious background fact), the author needs to assume that her explanation achieves minimal standards of plausibility and, assuming the author's conclusion sounds pretty sure of itself, the author needs to assume that there is *not* some other way to explain the background fact.

If an author is rebutting someone's position, she needs to assume that the reason she offers for her rebuttal actually conflicts with the position she's trying to reject. If an author is rejecting a conditional, she needs to provide a situation where the trigger occurred, but the outcome did not.

Negating Answers

One of the most reliable ways to get Necessary Assumption answers correct is to get good at the Negation Test: the correct answer, if negated, badly weakens the argument. An incorrect answer, if negated, doesn't weaken the argument. Negating a claim means *contradicting it in the most minimal fashion*. The negation of "All my friends are honest" isn't "None of my friends are honest", it's "at least one of my friends is not honest". There are a few standards to go by when negating:

- Don't negate every single answer as you read them. Try to get rid of some for easier reasons like Out of Scope or Too Strong wording. Use the negation test more to confirm the answer you're picking.
- If the truth value of an answer hinges on a quantity word, f.e. "Some clowns are scary", then negate the quantity term. Know your quantity yin-yangs (Some vs. None / All vs. Not all / Most vs. Not-Most, i.e. 51% vs. 49% / Many vs. Not-Many / Sometimes vs. Never)
- If the truth value hinges on the word *not*, then just remove the *not,* f.e. negating "Taking the vacation will not deplete Luke's savings" gives us "taking the vacation *will* deplete his savings".
- If the truth value hinges on the verb, negate the verb, f.e. negating "Washing dishes dries out your hands" gives us "Washing dishes *does not dry out* your hands".
- If the answer is conditional, don't negate it. Negating a conditional does not give you a conditional. If gives you one counterexample, in which the trigger happens but the outcome does not. Instead of negating conditional answers, just mentally or physically diagram the If / Then statement and ask yourself if the author's argument made that move. Most of these will be wrong because they'll be Backwards or Opposite logic.

Reading Goal

1. Find the Conclusion.
2. Find the Support.
3. Ask yourself if there's a New Term or idea in the Conclusion. (If so, that idea will almost always be in the correct answer)
4. If there is any conditional logic, or chain of ideas, or repeated ideas, then this problem is probably testing a missing link or fact. If there is conditional logic, mentally or physically diagram it. Link conditionals together where possible. Think about the missing conditional piece you would need to get from the Subject of the conclusion (Eddie) to the Predicate (is a great friend).
5. If there isn't conditional logic, switch into debate mode: *GIVEN the evidence, HOW COULD YOU ARGUE the anti-conclusion*?

Pre-phrase Goal

Because of the mixed bag nature of Necessary Assumption arguments, we'll find that sometimes we have a very specific idea we're looking for (*need to join 'easier to think' with 'solve difficult problem').* Other times we'll have a **functional** goal for the answer, but not specific wording. If an author is relying on a comparison where two things are

said to be similar, we might think, "Let's look for an answer that rules out a significant difference between the two things". If an author is concluding that X is the explanation for some Curious Fact, we might think, "Let's look for an answer that rules out an alternate explanation or that provides some fact that must be true for X to be a plausible explanation".

Necessary Assumptions are the opposite of Objections. If we would object to an author, "hey, maybe those two people are twins!", then we can say the argument was assuming "those two people are *not* twins". If we could tell an author was assuming "Jack likes cookies", then we could object to that argument by saying "Jack doesn't like cookies". So in some cases, we read a Necessary Assumption paragraph and can already hear something the author is assuming. In those cases, that's our pre-phrase. Other times, we don't hear an assumption, so we switch into debating mode and try to think of a possible objection. If we come up with Objection X, then we can pre-phrase, "Okay, the author is assuming that Objection X is *not* true."

Correct Answers

There are a few different ways to think about what makes a Necessary Assumption answer correct. They're all valid in all cases, but you may find that it's easier to process a correct answer using one formulation vs. another, depending on the problem:

- Which answer, when negated, most weakens the argument?
- Which answer can clearly be derived from the author's thinking?
- Which answer shows a move that the author clearly made?

The first one is well suited to answers with the word "not" in them, that are ruling out Objections. The second one is well suited to answers that are patching together language (like "easier to think" is relevant to "solve difficult problem"), or to answers that assume a relevant similarity or that assume a basic plausibility to an author's hypothesis. The third one is well suited to conditional logic answer choices.

Weak language is our friend. Correct answers frequently have watered down phrasings like "some, sometimes, can, may, might, not all, not always". **Ruling-out** language is also our friend. Many correct answers use the word *not*, next to the verb, to rule out some fact.

Incorrect Answers

- **Too Strong / Specific** - We're accusing the author of assuming the answer we pick, so we don't want to accuse them of something harsh or crazy sounding (unless they sounded that crazy, and they usually don't). Words that imply certainty are conditional, so we can evaluate those answers by comparing their conditional logic to the reasoning flow of the argument. But much of the time we can just hear that an idea is *way too* strong for the author to have committed herself to defending. Just like in Most Supported and Reading Comp, words like *most, typically, usually, tends to, generally, primarily, rarely* are usually wrong.
- **Out of Scope** - We're not speculating on what else the author might believe. If we didn't talk about it, then the author hasn't made any assumptions about it. (The one exception being that in causal arguments the author will be assuming

that some *other explanation* that we didn't talk about is *not* the actual causal explanation)

- **Opposite / Backwards Logic** - Lots of wrong answers are conditional logic relationships that don't go from Prem to Conclusion; they go from Conclusion to Premise, or they assume that Not-Premise leads to Not-Conclusion. There are lots of Fake Opposite answers that also just flip a premise. If an author said that "vinegar-based salad dressings are low in fat", a trap answer will say he's assuming that "non-vinegar-based salad dressings are high in fat". We can't do that.
- **Weakens** - Some wrong answers are actually objections. The correct answer, when *negated*, should weaken. But an answer, as stated, should never weaken.

Paradox

Keywords

Explain, resolve, paradox, discrepancy, apparent conflict

Examples

Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain the data from the study?
Which of the following, if true, most helps to resolve the apparent discrepancy?

Stimulus Tendencies

The paradox usually hinges around Causality and Comparisons.
We are usually needing to figure out the **Causal Difference-Maker** between two things, two groups, two situations, two timeframes.

- Given this sameness, how are they different?
- Given this difference, how are they the same?
- Given this positive, how is this seen as a negative?
- Given this negative, how is this seen as a positive?
- Given this plan, how come its objective wasn't achieved?
- Given X's alibi, how can we explain why Y happened?

Some **Explain** questions feel a little different. They don't necessarily pit two things in tension with each other. They just present something and ask us to Explain it. But these are 15% or less of Paradox questions.

On **Explain** question stems, you'll always see a specific reference to what we're trying to explain. If it says, "Which of the following, if true, most helps to explain Sarah's reaction to the gift", then we already know that everything else is background, and our job is simply to pick an answer that makes sense of Sarah's reaction.

On **Resolve** question stems, they're more likely to just use a generic term like "paradox, apparent conflict, discrepancy", so then it's more on us to figure out where the tension is (although half of the tension will always be the final claim).

Reading Goal

1. ***Understand the paradox.*** These are not arguments, so do not look for a Premise or Conclusion.
2. ***Find the Surprising Claim.*** It's almost always the final idea, and it's almost always prefaced by a pivot word like However / Yet / Nevertheless.
3. ***What Background Fact(s) makes that a surprise?*** Ask yourself, "Why would we have expected something different from this last, surprising claim?"

Frame the tension

GIVEN *the background claim(s),* HOW CAN I EXPLAIN *the surprising claim?*

Correct Answer

It gives us some way to make sense of the surprising claim or unexpected difference.

The stronger the wording, the more impact an answer potentially has, so this is a question type where we **Prefer Stronger Language**, and where we could consider **Weak Language = Red Flag** (sometimes, can, may, might, not all, not always).

Whenever a question stem says, "Which of the following, if true, most... ", (Paradox, Strengthen, and Weaken), a few things apply:

- We expect brand new things we haven't heard before
- We prefer stronger language over weaker language
- We will have to use a little bit of outside knowledge / common sense to connect what the answer is saying to the impact it has on the stimulus

Incorrect Answers

- **Opposite** - These actually *increase* the surprise
- **Explains Background** - These tell us more about why the background fact is true, but they don't help us understand why the surprising claim is true
- **No Distinction** - This is special trap answer that we see on Paradox; since we are almost always looking for some meaningful difference between two things / two groups / two timeframes / two situations, if an answer provides something that would be true for both things, for both situations, then it's useless to us.
- **Too Weak -** It's possible for an answer to lose out to the correct answer because it's worded much more weakly.

Parallel

Keywords

Most similar, parallels, pattern of reasoning, structure of reasoning

Examples

The pattern of reasoning in the argument is most similar to which of the following?
The pattern of reasoning in which of the following arguments most closely parallels that in the argument?

Stimulus Tendencies

These will (almost always) be **valid,** or at least highly reasonable arguments. We don't need to push back on the argument when we evaluate it, although recognizing that an original argument *is* 100% valid can make it that much easier to get rid of any answer choice whose argument is flawed.

Since the LSAT is testing patterns of structure, the arguments need a lot of Conditional or Quantified signposts, so that we can successfully represent them abstractly. About 70-75% of these arguments will contain Conditional Logic. The other 25-30% of them can be abstractly captured by some principle like, “if it ain’t broke, don’t fix it", or by some familiar LSAT reasoning pattern like "Just because two things are correlated, doesn't mean that one causes another, because they could both be effects of some third thing".

Here are some of the more common argument templates.

- All A's are B. All B's are C. X is an A. **Thus, X is a C.**
- If X, then Y or Z. X happened. Y didn't happen. **Thus, Z happened.**
- X is A or B. A doesn't seem possible. **Thus, X is probably B.**
- Most A's are B. Most A's are C. **Thus, Some B’s are C’s.**
- If X, then Y. But Y isn't true / isn't good. **So, not X / shouldn't do X.**

Here are some of the principles / patterns they've tested:

- You shouldn't do X, because whether you fail or succeed something bad happens.
- If it's been true in the past, it'll probably be true again.
- It's pointless to do X, because it's not worth the effort / doomed to fail / will make the problem worse.
- The principle/claim X is wrong, because here's a counterexample.

Reading Goal

1. Find the argument's pieces (Conc and Evid) and judge its validity.

2. Decide whether you're going to represent this by diagramming or whether you're going to boil the reasoning down to a slogan / principle.

3. Consider articulating for yourself the number of premises, the strength of each claim, the type of each claim, and the recipe of combining the ingredients.

This is the vocabulary we would typically use for type of claim:

- Conditional (keep track of **compounds: and's** and **or's** in trigger / outcome)
- Either/or
- Normative (should, ought, good, bad)
- Quantified (some, most, all, not all, few)
- Comparative (more, taller, smarter, weaker)
- Causal (leads to, results in)
- Statement of fact (usually that "fulfill" a condition from a conditional statement, thereby showing that the conditional applies to that specific case and something can be logically concluded: *All girl scouts sell cookies and Shavon is a girl scout. Jaden has never sold cookies.* This combination of one conditional and two facts lets us conclude 1. Shavon has sold cookies, and 2. Jaden isn't a girl scout.)

This is the vocabulary we would typically use to describe the strength of claims:

- Certain (all, must, only, can't, etc.)
- Probable (probably, usually, most, likely, etc.)
- Possible (some, can, may, not all, might)

Pre-phrasing

Rehearse your principle or abstract recipe, and also ask yourself "Which ingredient would be the easiest to find/confirm?" or "Which ingredient is my best initial reference point?" (f.e. "The conclusion needs to be an either/or claim" or "Let me first see if they're saying that one thing requires another"). You're doing this for two reasons:

1. You want a must-have you can easily scan for so that you can potentially disqualify a couple answers without having to fully read them.
2. There is often an ingredient that is a clear "jumping off point" because without it, you can't evaluate anything else. For example, if my structure were something like, "If X, then Y or Z. Y is not happening. Thus, either Z is happening or X is not happening," we can't evaluate whether the rest of the answer matches until we find a matching either/or conditional.

Correct Answers

The correct answer will be more similar than any of the other answer choices. It will almost always have the same number of premises as the original argument. The conclusion will be the same type of claim and strength of claim. However, it is very

common for the chronological order of claims to have been shuffled around. It doesn't matter in which order we get the Conclusion or each Premise, as long as we get them.

If we're ever not finding *any* answers that match, we may be looking for something too picky and need to soften our must-have list. If we find two answers that seem to match, then we need to get even pickier and look for some subtle difference between the two and compare it back to the original.

Incorrect Answers

- **Topic Trap** - Often one trap answer seems suspiciously similar to the original in terms of its topic (the correct answer has a similar logical structure but almost invariably is discussing a completely different topic)
- **Bad Premise Match** - There might be an ingredient entirely missing (a lot of wrong answers don't have the same number of premises as the original), or otherwise it will not quite match up in terms of type of claim or strength of claim.
- **Bad Conclusion Match** - It might be the wrong type of claim, the wrong strength of claim, or it might referring to the wrong thing when it comes to matching the flow of the original.
- **Validity Mismatch** - Most of the original arguments are valid or at least very reasonable. If we then read an answer that is clearly flawed, that's enough reason to reject it.

Parallel Flaw

Keywords

Most similar, parallels, flawed pattern of reasoning, erroneous reasoning, questionable reasoning

Examples

The flawed pattern of reasoning in the argument is most similar to which of the following?
The questionable pattern of reasoning in which of the following arguments most closely parallels that in the argument?

Stimulus Tendencies

These will tend to either be Conditional / Quantified flaws, or Famous Flaws. There are 5 or 6 famous flaws that show up a lot on these:

- Necessary vs. Sufficient (reading a conditional backwards or in opposite fashion)
- Part vs. Whole
- Failure to Consider Alternative Explanations
- Sampling
- Ad Hominem
- Unproven vs. Proven False

If there are **Quantifier** words like "all, some, most, few," it's usually a good idea to diagram those arguments, since the correct answer will match that structure. For example:

- All A's are B. All A's are C. Thus, All B's are C.
- Most A's are B. Most B's are C. Thus, Some A's are C.

Other arguments won't be Famous Flaw or Quantified, in which case we should try to think of an objection and then see if we can make that same objection work with each answer choice (it should work with the correct answer.) For example:

- Since no one can be both X and Y, if she's not X, she must be Y.(C*ouldn't she be **neither?**)*
- We need to choose between A and B. Since, she prefers B and he prefers A, we should go with B. (W*ait, why are you choosing **that** point of view, rather than the other?)*
- We can't prove that X is the culprit, nor can we prove Y is the culprit. Thus, we can't prove that X or Y is the culprit. (W*ait, what if they're the only two suspects? can't you say for sure it was one or both of them?)*

Reading Goal

1. Read the argument and try to find some Flaw
2. Was there any conditional logic? If so, look for illegal reversals or negations. Consider diagramming the parts.
3. Were there any quantifier words like some, most, all? Consider diagramming the recipe.
4. If there weren't conditional or quantified language, could this be committing a Sampling, Circular, Ad Hominem, Part vs. Whole, or Unproven vs. Proven False flaw?
5. If nothing has applied so far, how could we ACCEPT the evidence but FIGHT the conclusion? What objection would we make?

Pre-phrasing

- If we identified a famous flaw, we'll just be going to the answers thinking, f.e., "I need a Sampling flaw, where the sample size is too small".
- If we identified a conditional or quantified flaw, then we will probably have a 3 or 4 ingredient recipe of claims (usually 2 premises and 1 conclusion). • For all other cases, we need to think of our objection to the original argument in abstract terms. Subtract the topic and think about the form of the objection.

Correct Answer

Above all, the correct answer has to replicate the same flaw, or be vulnerable to the same objection. It will usually mimic all the same structural pieces, but there are exceptions to that. The other thing essential is the flaw.

If we're ever not finding *any* answers that match, we may be looking for something too

picky and need to soften our must-have list. If we find two answers that seem to match, then we need to get even pickier and look for some subtle difference between the two and compare it back to the original.

Incorrect Answers

- **Topic Trap** - Often one trap answer seems suspiciously similar to the original in terms of its topic (the correct answer has a similar logical structure but almost invariably is discussing a completely different topic)
- **Bad Premise Match** - There might be an ingredient entirely missing (a lot of wrong answers don't have the same number of premises as the original), or otherwise it will not quite match up in terms of type of claim or strength of claim.
- **Bad Conclusion Match** - It might be the wrong type of claim, the wrong strength of claim, or it might referring to the wrong thing when it comes to matching the flow of the original.
- **Validity Mismatch** - If we read an answer that is valid logic, then that's enough reason to reject it.

Principle-Strengthen

Principle-Strengthen + Principles in Answers

These are the most common type of Principle question. They actually feel way more like **Sufficient Assumption** than Strengthen. But we classify them under Strengthen because the question stem says "which principle *most* justifies", not "fully justifies". Nevertheless, come at these mofo's like they're Sufficient Assumption, and expect it to be all about pre-phrasing an "IF premise, THEN conclusion" conditional and then reading five answers that are fully of conditional logic trigger words. This is a question type where those with conditional logic skills can find quick eliminations, and those without conditional logic skills can be baited into picking answers that have the right ideas, but in the wrong logical order.

- Which of the following principles, if valid, most justifies the argument?

Principle-Strengthen + Principles in Stimulus

These have become more popular over the past twenty tests. They're pretty awesome! We're given a Principle, and then an argument is attempting to apply that principle. It will be concluding the right side of the principle, but it will always fail to completely establish the left side of the principle. So, all we need to do is pick an answer that finally makes clear that the left side of the principle has been triggered.

- Which of the following, if true, most justifies the application of the principle?

Principle-Strengthen + Principles in Answers

1. Find the CONCLUSION and the EVIDENCE.
2. Pre-phrase "IF premise, THEN conclusion".
3. The correct answer should sound like 1/2 Premise language, 1/2 Conclusion language.
4. Try to get rid of answer choices quickly if they don't have Conclusion language
5. Get rid of anything that puts the Conclusion on the left side of arrow.
6. If there are competing interests being weighed against each other, the correct answer may rank one thing as more important than another.

Principle-Strengthen + Principles in Stimulus

1. Diagram the Principle carefully.
2. Verify that the Application is concluding the right side of your rule. Ask yourself whether the Application established the left side of the rule (it didn't, but in what way did it fall short?)
3. Go find an answer that clearly establishes the trigger of the principle is applicable.

Principle-Conform

There are three varieties of **Principle-Conform**

- The stimulus is a principle (or pair of principles)
- The answers are principles
- There are no explicit principles, just implied/illustrated ones

Principles in Stimulus

When the stimulus is providing an explicit principle (or two), we're usually being tested on our ability to apply a conditional rule.

To find an answer that Conforms to this principle, we want an answer where the situation described matches the Trigger of the principle, and the judgment concluded matches the Outcome of the principle. (Even when the principles aren't expressed as conditionals, there will still usually be two things we need to make sure match up).

Principles in Answers

It's essentially the same mindset as a Principle-Strengthen question. We read the argument and then anticipate the principle underlying the argument by pre-phrasing "IF evidence, THEN conclusion". We expect the correct answer to *Link* language from the Evidence to the Conclusion's language. All that's different is that because the question stem says *conform* to the author's reasoning, we can't pick an answer that's overly strong. (That usually doesn't matter, but occasionally it does)

Implicit Principles

These feel similar to Parallel reasoning questions, because we're given an argument in the stimulus, and then each answer choice is its own argument on its own unique topic. We're looking for an underlying similarity to connect the correct answer to the original argument.

On Parallel questions, those similarities come more in the form of technical / structural similarities (i.e. "Since the original argument had a *Most* premise and a *Some* premise, the correct answer's argument will also have those features").

But with Principle-Conform it's more about the underlying gist or rule-of-thumb. We don't try to diagram the arguments. We just want to articulate a general moral to the story or operating principle that's guiding the author's thinking, and then we try to find an answer that matches that.

Role

Keywords

Claim plays what role, statement figures in which way

Examples

The claim that salad dressing is not legally allowed to be marketed as shampoo plays what role in the argument?
The statement that croutons are the Devil's handmaiden figures in the argument in which of the following ways?

Stimulus Tendencies

LSAC is seeking to make it harder than usual to find the Conclusion, so the Conclusion is only the final claim about 10% of the time. 90% of the time the final claim (or the final 2 or 3 claims) is support.

It's very common on Role questions to have **rebuttal-style** arguments in which the author is arguing *against* something. We also want to be on high alert for **Intermediate (Subsidiary) Conclusions**. This is the question on LSAT where we are most likely to need to worry about an Intermediate Conclusion.

Other times, the Conclusion will be indirectly revealed by **Support language** (F.A.B.S.) like "for, after all, because, since".

Sometimes, our best clue about where the conclusion is will be an **Opinion Indicator** like "probably, apparently, evidently".

Beware that there may be **Intermediate Conclusions.** They will pass the Support test because they will have their own premise. But they are there to support the Main Conclusion.

Reading Goal

1. Find the conclusion.
2. Make sure that it sounds like **Author's Opinion** (facts ≠ conclusions), is **Supported** by at least one explicit claim, and isn't an **Intermediate Conclusion**.
3. Find the supporting idea(s).
4. Now take a look at the question stem and see if it was asking about the conclusion or one of the supporting ideas. If so, head over to the answers. If not, think about whether this claim was something Neutral to the conclusion (like Background info) or something Opposing to the author's argument (an opponent's conclusion, an opponent's premise, or a concession to the opponent the author makes)

Pre-phrase Goal
Don't overcomplicate it. Go with one of these:

- Main Conclusion
- Supports
- Opposes
- Neutral

Correct Answers
The correct answer doesn't say anything descriptively wrong. The other four do. (Maybe once in a blue moon, you'd have two "true" answers, where you'd have to ask which one's better.)
The most common correct answer is Premise or some other way of describing Supporting Idea.
Easier Role questions will stick to classic language like Premise and Conclusion, whereas harder Role questions will often switch to less familiar abstract language or synonyms.

- **Main Conclusion** - The claim the author seeks to establish, a generalization supported by evidence, the only conclusion,
- **Premise** - Support, partial support (just means there's more than one premise), evidence, illustration of, example of, unsupported premise
- **Intermediate Conclusion** - Subsidiary conclusion, supported premise, a conclusion but not the main conclusion, a statement for which some support is provided but is used to support the main conclusion
- **Opposing Position** - The view the argument is designed to discredit, the claim the author attempts to show is false

Incorrect Answers

- **Wrong Ingredient** - These describe something in the paragraph, but not the claim we were asked about
- **Too Strong** - Some answers that about an idea being *required* or *sufficient* for the conclusion
- **Didn't Happen** - These reference something that never happened in the

paragraph
- **Wrong Conclusion** - Lots of wrong answers correctly call the claim a Premise but then say it's supporting some idea that doesn't match the argument's Conclusion

Strengthen

Keywords

Most strengthens, most supports, argument / reasoning / claim

Examples

Which of the following, if true, most strengthens the argument?
The reasoning above is most supported by which of the following?

Stimulus Tendencies

- Lots of **causal** arguments -- A Curious Fact (a correlation, an experiment, a survey, a statistic) followed by a Conclusion that makes a Causal Interpretation of that curious fact.
- Lots of **comparative** arguments -- The author will often assume "Because A and B are similar in this way, they'll be similar in that way." Or "because this was true before, it will be true again".
- Many **predictions / plans / recommendations** -- These are also implicitly comparative, because we have to analyze all the potential differences between Present vs. Future, or Before-Plan vs. With-Plan.
- Not a lot of conditional logic.

Reading Goal

1. Find the Conclusion.
2. Find the Support.
3. Ask yourself if you see any Logic Gaps or can think of anything the author is Assuming.
4. Consider how you would attack this argument if you wanted to argue the Anti Conclusion.
5. Think about what sort of evidence would make this argument more compelling.

Pre-phrase Goal

If we hear something being assumed or sense a term shift or New Term in the conclusion, then we look for an answer connecting those ideas.

- For **Causal** arguments, primarily expect to *add plausibility* to the author's hypothesis (No Cause, No Effect data points, more Cause/Effect data points, or something else that explains how the causal connection would work or why it's a

likely hypothesis), but we also might see correct answers *ruling out* an alternative explanation for the evidence.

- For **Comparison** arguments, we want to be more convinced that the two things being compared or similar (if the author is assuming they're comparable) or that the two things being compared are different (if the author is assuming they're different).

Incorrect Answers

- Do they **Weaken** or feel like they're going **Wrong Direction**?
- Do they have **No Impact** (out of scope)?
- Are they **Too Weak**? (*some, sometimes, can, may, not all* = one data point)

Correct Answers

- Provides a Missing Link in the argument's internal logic?
- Makes two things being compared seem more fair to compare? •
Rules out an alternate explanation for a curious fact?
- Increases the plausibility of the author's causal story? (#1 way - No Cause, No Effect way)
- Makes a survey / sample / study / correlation seem more trustworthy or robust? (rare)

Weaken

Keywords

Most weakens, most undermines, casts doubt on, fails to consider, ignores
Examples

Which of the following, if true, most weakens the argument?
Which of the following, if true, casts the most doubt on Tom's reasoning?
The argument is most vulnerable to criticism because it fails to consider

Stimulus Tendencies

- **Causal** arguments -- A Curious Fact (a correlation, an experiment, a survey, a statistic) followed by a Conclusion that shows the Author's Causal Interpretation of that fact.
- **Comparative** arguments -- The author will often assume "because A and B are similar in this way, they'll be similar in that way." Or "because this was true before, it will be true again".
- **Predictions -** What could be different in the future that would keep this prediction from coming true?
- **Plan / Solution -** How could this fail to achieve the goal?

Reading Goal

1. Find the Conclusion.

2. Find the Support.
3. Figure out how to argue the Anti-Conclusion, by framing the argument as

GIVEN [this evidence], HOW CAN I ARGUE [the Anti-Conclusion]?

Pre-phrase Goal

- If we hear a **Term Shift**, we can look for an answer making those two things seem like they're *not* connected.
- For **Causal** arguments, most correct answers suggest an **alternate explanation** for the Curious Fact in the evidence. Others will make the Author's Causal Story **less plausible**, often through a Cause / Effect mismatch (cause was present, but effect was absent / cause was absent, but effect was still present)
- For **Comparison** arguments, we will usually be asking ourselves, "What could be a **meaningful difference** between these two things?"

Incorrect Answers

- **Strengthen** or drift in that direction
- **No Impact** - Out of Scope / Irrelevant Distinction / Irrelevant Comparison
- **Too Weak** - Words like *some, sometimes, can, may, not all* = one data point

Correct Answers

- Attack a Missing Link in the argument's internal logic?
- Make two things being compared seem meaningfully different? •
Provide an alternate explanation for a curious fact?
- Undermine the plausibility of the author's causal story?
- Cheapen the data from a survey / sample / study / correlation? (rare)

Reasoning Types

Causation

By Question Type

STRENGTHEN / WEAKEN / EVALUATE - Tons of arguments present a Curious Fact in the Evidence and then Conclude something Causal. We end up needing to consider **alternate storylines** as well as the plausibility of the **author's storyline**.

FLAW - When authors present a correlation or other Curious Fact and then overconfidently conclude that one thing causes another, we can criticize them for "inferring a cause from a mere correlation" or for "failing to consider alternative explanations". (There is a related trap answer that is never correct: "Mistakes cause for effect". It is okay to say the author has failed to consider that *maybe* she's got the causal picture backwards, but we aren't allowed to definitively say she got it backwards)

NECESSARY ASSUMPTION - When the author concludes that "X caused Y", she needs to assume "there is **not** some other storyline for what caused Y" as well as that "X causing Y is a plausible storyline".

MUST BE TRUE / MOST SUPPORTED - Sometimes there are **chains** of causal connections (X causes Y. Y causes Z.), and so the correct answer will reward us for deriving the idea that "X causes Z" or that "if we had less X, we'd have less Z". There are a lot of questions on Most Supported where the correct answer reinforces a **Causal Difference-Maker**. If we're told that X is true, and "because of this / due to this" Y is true, then the correct answer will synthesize/regurgitate that "things like X can cause things like Y". On some Most Supported questions, they're playing a game of **Solve the Causal Mystery**, where they lay out a few factors and the correct answer offers the most conservative causal guess about how to explain this situation.

PARALLEL FLAW - Not too many of these involve causality, but Parallel Flaw questions will occasionally test the Causal Flaw, where an author is too confident in her specific causal guess, even though other (potentially more likely) explanations are possible.

PARADOX - Tons of correct answers will involve us needing some potential causal storyline for how two things could be different (or the same, depending). We're usually scanning the answers looking for some **Causal Difference-Maker** that would show why two different animals, or two different groups, or two different time periods, or two different situations end up looking differently.

Causal Verbs
Keywords: causes, leads to, results in, has the effect of, promotes, inhibits, raises,

lowers, deters, encourages, influences, contributes to, is a factor in

Causal Difference-Maker Language

When these words start a sentence, it signifies that there's a causal connection between the previous sentence and this sentence.

Keywords: because of this, due to this, this allows, this leads to, this makes possible

On Most Supported tasks, it is legal to say, "If the Causal Difference-Maker weren't present, the effect probably wouldn't have been present (or less of the effect would be present)".

Curious Facts

These are almost all going to involve some sort of asymmetric comparison:

- **Ever since** we raised the minimum sentence for burglary, there have been **fewer** burglaries.
- People who know how to play chess **tend to** be good at math.
- Subjects assigned to the group that heard Mozart were **less likely than those who didn't** to report being stressed by the newspaper headlines they read.
- Knowing French is **associated** with having **higher than average** numbers of romantic partners.
- **Only 20%** of the cars on the road are red, **but 45%** of speeding tickets are given to people who drive red cars.

Keywords: correlated with, associated with, more likely to, less likely to, tend to

Curious Fact → Author's Causal Story

There's a huge swath of arguments in LR that fall into the same bucket:

- The author presents some **Curious Fact** in the evidence. (a statistic, the results of a study, an asymmetric comparison)
- The conclusion offers a **Hypothesis** / **Explanation**./ **Interpretation**

There are two different ways to affect a causal argument:

1. Propose or undermine **Other Ways** to explain the Curious Fact
2. Support or undermine the **Plausibility** of the Author's Story

Here's how correct answers for causal arguments play out on various question types:

- **WEAKEN** - They typically suggest some **Other Way** to explain the Curious Fact (an alternative explanation). Sometimes they undermine the plausibility of the Author's Story either by suggesting why it's an unlikely hypothesis or by providing data points that *don't* fit with the author's cause / effect relationship (Cause without Effect, or Effect without Cause)
- **STRENGTHEN** - They typically **increase Plausibility** of the Author's Story, particular by offering data points showing that where the Cause was absent the Effect was absent. Sometimes they **rule out** some Other Way to explain the

Curious Fact.

- **FLAW** - They say that it is a flaw to assume that X causes Y, just because they're correlated or just because that *could* be an explanation. Failure to consider alternative explanations for the evidence = Causal Flaw.
- **NECESSARY ASSUMPTION** - They tend to **rule out** some Other Way, but occasionally they provide a missing link that allows the Author's Story to be plausible.

Conditional Logic

Importance

Although this topic might affect less than 1/3 of the test, it's common for it to affect 1/2 or more of a student's incorrect answers. Conditional logic is found throughout LR and LG. In LR, there will often be conditional logic in the stimulus as well as the answer choices. In LG, around half of all games have at least one conditional logic rule.

Most of us aren't very good at spotting or dealing with conditional logic. It's not something we've had to use in our pre-LSAT life. It often feels too hard, too mechanical, too mathematical. A lot of LSAT students are very good readers, very good at intuitive holistic thinking, and thus struggle with conditional logic unless they really learn some new skills and switch to those tools whenever conditional logic is on the menu.

Relevant Question Types

Here's where conditional logic will **typically** show up:

- Sufficient Assumption / Principle-Strengthen (stimulus and answers)
- Apply the Principle (stimulus)
- Parallel / Parallel Flaw (stimulus and answers)
- Must Be True / Must Be False (stimulus and answers)

Here's where conditional logic will **often** show up:

- Necessary Assumption (stimulus and answers)
- Most Strongly Supported (stimulus and answers)
- Flaw (if they're testing the **Necessary vs. Sufficient** flaw)

Throughout these problems, look for keywords indicating conditional logic. Listen for claims with total **certainty**, or ones mentioning **requirements**. Jot down the "X → Y" version of these claims, and then also write the contrapositive.

- (Put this on the **LEFT**): if, when, the only, all, each, any, every, no, whenever, whoever, wherever
- (Put this on the **RIGHT**): only, only if, requires, depends on, must, ensures,

guarantees, implies, necessitates
- (Do an **IF-NOT** translation: put the attached idea on the left, but negated): unless, without, until, except perhaps
- **No** A's are B = All A's are **~B**
- **R**equired things = **R**ight side of arrow

If you have **more than one conditional**, check to see if they **chain** together. You may have to write a contrapositive of one of them to see how they would connect. Conditionals chain together when you have the same idea on opposite sides, or opposite ideas on the same side.

Same Idea / Opposite Side

- A → B (B is on the right side)
- B → C (B is on the left side)
- Combined, it yields A → B → C

Opposite Idea / Same Side

- X → Y (Y is on the right side)
- Z → ~Y (~Y is on the right side)
- Combined, it yields X → Y → ~Z

If you have **conditionals + facts**, check to see whether any facts trigger the conditional or its contrapositive. Given a rule like, "All unanimous votes occur under time constraints", it would look like this:

Unanimous Vote → Time Constraint
~Time Constraint → ~Unanimous Vote

The two triggers are *Unanimous Vote* and *No Time Constraint,* so we would examine any of the facts presented and see whether they mentioned there being either a Unanimous Vote or a *lack* of Time Constraint, which would trigger this rule and allow us to infer the right side.

Comparison

Assumes a Similarity

EXAMPLE: Linda loves 90's Hip-Hop, and she's really into Bubba's Nasty 90's Mix on Spotify. Thus, Jacob will probably be really into Bubba's Nasty 90's Mix too. **Strengthen by making it seem like** Jacob is also into 90's Hip-Hop. **Weaken by making it seem like** Jacob isn't into 90's Hip-Hop, or isn't into the stuff that Bubba plays on dat Nasty mix of his.

EXAMPLE: LSAT students should never take full-length practice tests in the weeks leading up to taking an official LSAT. After all, taking an LSAT, like running a marathon, is a huge test of endurance, and marathon runners do not practice for their races by running full marathons in the weeks leading up to a race.
Strengthen by making it seem like LSAT and marathons are fair to compare.

Weaken by making it seem like there is something meaningfully different about LSAT taking and marathon running (maybe it's far easier for the brain to recover from the endurance test of an LSAT than it is for bones and muscles to recover from the endurance test of a marathon).

Assumes a Difference

EXAMPLE: Paula and Jacoby have both never been able to complete a 720 on the half pipe before. But Paula, unlike Jacoby, will probably be able to nail a 720 by the end of this vacation. After all, she's currently working with a snowboarding instructor.
Strengthen by making it seem like Jacoby is not *also* working with a snowboarding instructor.
Weaken by making it seem like Jacoby has done or is doing something that would match or exceed the benefit that Paula is getting from her snowboarding instructor.

EXAMPLE: We just got back the results from the focus group on Presley's ad campaign. They found it, "offensive to older people". Thus, we should go with Marley's ad campaign instead.
Strengthen by making it seem like Marley's ad campaign *isn't* offensive to older people.
Weaken by making it seem like Marley's campaign is just as offensive to the elderly, or point out some other detriment it has that would match or exceed the negative of Presley's ad campaign.

Past vs. Present

EXAMPLE: Paula and Jacoby have both never been able to complete a 720 on the half pipe before. Thus, by the time this vacation is over, they will have again failed to nail a 720 on the half-pipe.
Strengthen by making it seem like the past = present in any other regard that might affect their performance. (they're in comparable shape, they're comparably motivated, they're comparably uninjured, their understanding of snowboarding hasn't significantly improved).
Weaken by making it seem like there's some important difference between before and now.

Present vs. Future

EXAMPLE: Over the past decade, the electorate has gotten increasingly polarized and radicalized by partisan media sources. Thus, ten years from now, we probably won't even be able to have conversations with people from another political party. **Strengthen by making it seem like** trends will continue or lean even more in the same direction.
Weaken by making it seem like something important is going to change (Kanye wins the Presidency as a unity candidate), or something about the current trend is being overlooked (it's driven by ~80 year old billionaires who will soon be dead).

Current World vs. World of Plan / Recommendation

EXAMPLE: Jasper has had a hard time connecting with his grandmother. He should start watching more daytime soap operas.

Strengthen by making it seem like this plan will work / it's feasible / it's targets a meaningful issue ... the grandma loves daytime soap operas and would be very enthused to talk about them with Jasper ... Jasper wouldn't have to sacrifice going to school in order to watch these daytime soaps.
Weaken by making it seem like this plan isn't feasible / people won't be willing to cooperate as the plan intends / the plan will backfire for some reason ... Jasper only has streaming TV and can't see satellite TV like daytime soaps .. Grandma only likes discussing soaps with her female friends ... Jasper and his grandma would have very conflicting opinions on what's going on in these shows, adding strain to their relationship.

Anti-Causal

EXAMPLE: Ivan and Crosby both updated their Tinder profile, but only Ivan updated his picture with a headshot done by a professional photographer. In the month following their profile updates, they each got around 100 matches. Therefore, Ivan's paying for that professional photographer was apparently a waste of money.
Strengthen by making it seem like Ivan and Crosby were similar in any other meaningful regard (how attractive they are, how good/bad their personality description is, how many Matches they were previously getting).
Weaken by making it seem like Ivan and Crosby were *not* fair to compare from the start ... Ivan was starting from a lower reference point, and so achieving an equal number of matches to Crosby is actually showing that the pro photographer *did* make a difference (Ivan's less appealing / Crosby already had a pro photo for his pic / Ivan used to only get 40 matches per month whereas Crosby had been getting 80 per month).

Percentage vs. Amount

EXAMPLE: The average age of students at Hank's Ballroom Dancing School has decreased in recent years. Evidently, there are more and more young people rediscovering this timeless style of dancing.
Strengthen by making it seem like there are at least as many older people as there were before (rule out the possible objection that the average age went down not because *younger people joined* but because *older people left*)
Weaken by making it seem like the real reason that the average age has gone down is because there aren't as many older people or find a way to make it seem implausible that ballroom dancing is increasing in popularity among younger people.

Pros vs. Cons

EXAMPLE: People who start smoking cigarettes regularly tend to have less appetite than they did before smoking. So, if you want to be healthier, try starting a cigarette habit so that you can lose some weight!
Strengthen by making it seem like the advantages to smoking outweigh the disadvantages.
Weaken by making it seem like even though smoking cigs might do *one* thing that could make you healthier (help you lose weight), it might have some negatives associated with it that would outweigh the advantages.

EXAMPLE: The Baxter vacuum has more rug settings than The Suckster. Thus, Reggie, who is in the market for a new vacuum, should buy the Baxter rather than the Suckster.
Strengthen by making it seem like Reggie cares at least somewhat about having lots of rug settings, or by providing other ways in which the Baxter is equal to or better than the Suckster.
Weaken by making it seem like Reggie doesn't care about number of settings, or that most of the extra settings are dumb/useless, or by providing any sense in which the Baxter is *worse* than the Suckster (price, weight, convenience, etc.)

Complete the Analogy

Lots of examples of Logical Completion (i.e. *fill in the blank*) LR questions involve pulling together two strands of a conversation to complete a comparison. EXAMPLE: Singing an opera is just like running a marathon. Just as you wouldn't want to run a marathon without first stretching out your tendons, clearly _____ . **Complete the analogy by making it seem like** we should "stretch out our tendons" before we sing an opera (limber up our vocal cords?)

Explain Curious Fact

When Causation appears in the Assumption Family, it almost always involves an author speculating a possible Explanation to account for a given Curious Fact. We learn to consider alternate explanations and to evaluate the plausibility of the author's explanation.
This type of argument is particularly common in Strengthen / Weaken / Evaluate, but it will also show up a fair amount on Flaw and Necessary Assumption.

Prephrasing, by Question Type

STRENGTHEN

By **ruling out** an Alternate Explanation for curious fact
OR
By **increasing** the plausibility of the Author's Explanation.
The 2nd option is more common on Strengthen, and the most common type of plausibility strengthener is an answer that shows "things not exposed to the cause do not exhibit the effect".

WEAKEN

By **suggesting** an Alternate Explanation for curious fact
OR
By **lowering** the plausibility of the Author's Explanation.
The 1st option is more common on Weaken.

EVALUATE

The correct answer choice asks a question whose answer would suggest an Alternate Explanation for the curious fact, or whose answer would establish a baseline of plausibility for the Author's Explanation. The 1st option is more common.

FLAW

By complaining that the author has over confidently assumed one specific causal relationship from evidence that could be interpreted different ways,
OR
By complaining that the author has failed to consider an Alternate Explanation for the curious fact
OR
By complaining that the author has failed to consider some fact that would hurt the plausibility of the Author's Explanation.
The 1st option is most common on Flaw (just describing that the author's conclusion is too aggressively sure of itself, given the evidence).

NECESSARY ASSUMPTION

By **ruling out** an Alternate Explanation for curious fact
OR
By **establishing** some fact that's necessary for the Author's Explanation to be plausible.

The 1st option is more common on Necessary Assumption.

Find the Curious Fact
Look for an asymmetry between two groups or two situations or two timeframes. Look for a correlation or statistical change. Or just look for any funky fact that makes you scratch your head and think, "why?"
examples

- *People who write poetry are more likely than those who don't to be in committed relationships*
- *Revenue at our company decreased by 17% last week*
- *This year's craft fair had fewer macaroni sculptures than before* • The purple catfish is known to circle around an area more than 100 times before deciding to lay its eggs there
- In a study, a group of people who hate vegetables all had the same gene, XRV20, in common

Ask Yourself the Curious Question
Turn these facts into questions.

- Why is there a correlation between poetry and relationships?
- Why did revenue go down 17% last week?
- Why are there fewer macaroni sculptures this year? (or, why were there more macaroni sculptures last year?)

• Why does the purple catfish make 100+ circles before laying its eggs? • How come all the veggie haters have the same gene in common?

Sometimes the easiest way to find the Curious Question is to look at the Conclusion and picture the question that it's answering.
CONCLUSION: Apparently, Jim was drinking the night of his accident.
The *question must have been*, "Why did Jim get into an accident?"
CONCLUSION: Scientists hypothesize that the crickets use this wax to fortify their nest.
The question must have been, "How is this wax helpful to crickets?"

Articulate the Author's Causal Storyline (Explanation)
Make sure to spell out every step in the causal sequence of the author's story. They frequently leave many parts of it implied.
Most people who scored an eventual 170+ on their LSAT took a practice test on LawHub. Thus, if you want to get into a top law school, you should take a practice test on LawHub.
The causal story here is something like, "You don't have a 170 yet. A 170+ would be very helpful, if not necessary, to get into a top law school. If you take a practice test on LawHub, it will help you to raise your score to 170+."
Pose the Two-Pronged Question

1. Is there some **other way** to explain the Curious Fact?
2. How plausible is the **author's way**?

Remind yourself, based on the question type, whether you want the answer to suggest / rule out an Alternate Explanation, or whether you want the answer to increase / decrease the plausibility of the Author's Explanation.

Categorize the Correct Answers
When you're reviewing these questions, the skill you're trying to develop is the ability to speak this language:
"Choice (B) is correct because it **rules out** an Alternate Explanation for why all the birds were lethargic."

Famous Flaws

Where do we care?

These patterns are primarily of importance when it comes to **Flaw** and **Parallel Flaw** questions, although a couple of them (Causal and Nec vs. Suff) represent Reasoning Patterns (Causation and Conditional Logic) that permeate most of the LR section.

Why do we care?

Flaw is the most prevalent question type in LR, and around 40% of the answer choices on Flaw refer to one of these ten famous flaws. If you wanted to memorize a handful more, then you'd get around 13-15 types of flaws worth memorizing. The primary value

of knowing them will be **eliminating wrong answers**. Most of the time we see these Famous Flaws in an answer choice, they'll be wrong. But sometimes, maybe 35% of the time, the actual problem in the Flaw stimulus *is* one of these Famous Flaws.

On **Parallel Flaw**, we need to be able to either construct an abstract recipe of what the argument has done or to label it with some sort of Objection. For this latter category, the conversational objection we would think of is usually one of the top 6 Famous Flaws (Nec vs. Suff, Causal, Part vs. Whole, Sampling, Ad Hom, or Unproven vs. Proven False).

Tell me the Famous Flaws, already!

Here is a description and an example of the top 10 **Famous Flaws** that show up in answer choices, followed by a few more that almost made the cut.

Necessary vs. Sufficient - **T**aking a conditional relationship and then illegally thinking through it in backwards or opposite fashion. This is **frequently** the actual flaw on Flaw and Parallel Flaw questions.

- *People who have seen "The 13th" have a great understanding of the US prison system. Since Megan still hasn't seen that documentary, she must have a poor understanding of the US prison system.*
- *People who have seen "The 13th" have a great understanding of the US prison system. Jane understands the US prison system really well, so clearly she has seen "The 13th".*

Causal - Overconfidently concluding one possible causal interpretation of a curious fact, usually a Correlation, when other possible interpretations exist.

- *People who have been enlisted in the military are more likely than those who haven't been to have excellent physiques. Evidently, military recruitment officers select their future soldiers in large part based on the applicant's fitness and strength.*

Part vs. Whole - Assuming that a trait that is true of each Part of a collective is therefore true of the Whole, or vice versa.

- *The military is part of the government, and the military is conducted with lots of honor and discipline. Thus, the government overall is conducted with lots of honor and discipline.*
- *Since rat poison is very harmful if ingested, each ingredient in rat poison would be very harmful if ingested.*

Unproven vs. Proven False - Pointing out that someone failed to prove X is true, and then concluding that this means that X is false.

- *Billy says that his uncle was related to Elvis, but he hasn't been able to connect them on Ancestry.com. Thus, Billy's uncle was **not** related to Elvis.*
- *Some claim that the Atlanta Braves should change their name because they are the only major sports team that still has a Native American mascot. However, the*

Chicago Blackhawks still have a Native American mascot. Thus, the Braves should not change their name.

Ad Hominem - Dismissing a point of view because the source has a biased interest or has conflicting past behavior.

- *My friend Sameer says that social workers would be better at responding to domestic abuse calls than would armed police officers. But we can ignore this notion, since Sameer is a social worker and so his industry would benefit were cities to make this switch.*
- *My governor is telling me that we should all wear masks now, but we should not heed her words. After all, she was vocally against wearing masks a month ago.*

Sampling - Extrapolating/generalizing too readily from a small sample, while failing to consider that the sample might be biased, too small, or unrepresentative.

- *Charlie, a staunch Republican, is from San Francisco and works for a theater company. Since Sheila is also from San Francisco and also works for a theater company, she is probably a staunch Republican too.*
- *Today's youth prefer comic books to literature. After all, in a survey conducted at last year's Comic-Con, over 85% of the young people surveyed reported liking comic books much more than novels.*

There are several things you can do, in complementary fashion, to increase your facility with Famous Flaws:

- Flip through a bunch of Flaw and Parallel Flaw questions, mainly scanning the answers on Flaw to see if you recognize any of these famous flaws, or by reading through the arguments to see if any of them seem like they are committing one of these flaws.
- Create your own flashcards (potentially reversible ones), where you either see the name of a famous flaw and quiz yourself on what an answer choice describing that flaw would sound like, or vice versa (you read the answer choice and quiz yourself on whether you can name the flaw)
- Write your own example set for these flaws. For the flaws that have more than one style, try writing an example for each style. Send them to another LSAT student, or post on Reddit, or email Laura / Matt / Patrick if you want some feedback on them.

Irrelevant Rebuttal - Rebutting someone's claim or argument by mischaracterizing it in some Straw Man way or by bringing up something wholly irrelevant to the original claim.

- *My neighbor complains about how loud my music is, saying that the bass frequencies rattle all her furniture. But she must be lying, because I only play country music, not rock.*

False Choice - Acting like you have to choose between two options even though you never established those are *the only* two options.

- *We could use Grandma's birthday money to buy the new Mario Kart. But we could also use it to buy a rope swing for the yard. Since we can't find Mario Kart available anywhere online, we'll have to buy the rope swing.*

Relative vs. Absolute - Getting mixed up with Percents vs. Amounts, or confusing more/less language with yes/no language.

- *Some say that older people are never great at video games, but they're wrong. After all, Grandma is much better than Uncle Toby at* ***Mario Kart***

Inappropriate Appeal - Your evidence is a plea for sympathy, you cite an "authority" without establishing credibility, or you favor one source's opinion over another source's, without justifying your pick. Almost always wrong answers:

- *Elon Musk tweeted that concerns about the impact of 5g radiation are conspiracy theories, so we needn't worry about renting this house next to a 5g cell tower. (Appeal to Authority)*
- *I know I was speeding, Officer, but you shouldn't give me a ticket because it would ruin my Anniversary. (Appeal to Emotion)*
- *The majority of voters in Country A don't believe rising sea levels pose a problem for their country, so we should abandon legislation that would protect the coast against what local climatologists say is a looming threat. (Appeal to Popular Opinion)*

Circular Reasoning - The premise of an argument restates or assumes the conclusion.

- *The LSAT is clearly the hardest grad school test, because all the other tests people take to go to grad school pale in comparison to the difficulty of the LSAT.*

Internal Contradiction - Something the author says undermines or contradicts something else they say

- *LSAT is an incredibly challenging test for anyone who takes it. However, if you commit to Eddie Spaghetti's Steady LSAT Readiness protocol, you will soon be feeling like LSAT is no harder than a kindergarten spelling quiz.*

Equivocation - Using the same "term" or concept to mean two very different things.

- *Some question whether Egypt condones Romania's recent military buildup on their eastern border. But clearly Egypt sanctions this activity, since in the weeks following the Romanian military's actions, Egypt issued sanctions against Romania.*